Princess and the Hustler: Understanding the Text

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

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Written by: Harish Vijayan
Reviewed by: Nick Redgrove
Updated on 16 September 2025

All questions in the IGCSE encourage an informed personal response, which means that it is not enough just to know the text you are being examined on really well; you also need to develop a sound understanding of the themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events in the play you have studied, as well as an understanding of the significance of a particular moment or scene in relation to the whole text. You also need to demonstrate an awareness of the text as a piece of drama and show an appreciation of the play on stage. All of this will help you to develop a sustained, critical understanding of the text, which will allow you to demonstrate individuality and insight.

Each of the sub-topics below will help you to develop a better understanding of the text:

- Historical context
- Social context
- Literary context

Princess & The Hustler: historical context

The Windrush generation

- British **colonisation** of Jamaica began in 1655 and it remained under British rule until its independence in 1962, resulting in many Jamaicans continuing to feel a strong sense of connection to Britain:
  - The British colonial government promoted loyalty through annual events like Empire Day, where people in Jamaica celebrated being part of the British Empire
  - Britain was often referred to as the "mother country" by Jamaicans
  - Jamaican schoolchildren learned about Britain and were often encouraged to view England as wealthy, cultured and the model of civilisation
- From 1948, people from the Caribbean were given the right to work and live in Britain, prompting a wave of migration between 1948 and 1973:
  - This group became known as the **Windrush Generation**:

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

- Many migrants arrived expecting a warm welcome as fellow British citizens who were ready to contribute to post-war British society:
  - They soon discovered they were not accepted as "truly" British by many white Britons
  - Racist hostility and systemic barriers to housing and employment were common, and immigrants were frequently met with suspicion and prejudice

How this links to Princess & The Hustler	
Windrush	Princess' parents, Wendell and Mavis, are part of the Windrush generation. Their experiences reflect the hope many migrants had for a better life in Britain, alongside the reality of prejudice and exclusion they faced upon arrival.
Integration	Wendell is particularly vocal about the difficulty he has had integrating into British society. He refers to being underappreciated for his military service in England and how hard it is to find work as a result of racist attitudes.
Racist attitudes	The play shows both overt and subtle racism: the societal prejudice that limits opportunities for black people and the casual everyday discrimination that undermines Princess' ambitions. The backdrop of the Bristol Bus Boycott highlights the collective fight against these injustices, showing how communities came together to demand change. Margot also uses language that suggests that he has negative preconceptions of the black community. For example, referring to Margot as a "good sort and not one to rock the boat", suggesting approval for her political **passivity**, and implying that those who agitate for positive change are the opposite.

Help me understand

Princess & The Hustler: social context

Bristol in the 1960s

- In the early 1960s — when Princess & The Hustler is set — racial discrimination was still legal in Britain, and tensions between black communities and white-dominated institutions were high:
  - In Bristol, the local branch of the Transport and General Workers' Union (TGWU) and the Bristol

- This led to the Bristol Bus Boycott of 1963, a landmark protest organised by members of the West Indian community, including Paul Stephenson and Roy Hackett, and inspired by the American civil rights movement
- The boycott lasted for four months and was successful in ending the bus company's discriminatory hiring practices

How this links to Princess & The Hustler	
The Bristol Bus Boycott	Protests relating to the bus boycott are first mentioned by Leon, who suggests his father is organising a meeting to discuss opposing the colour bar, which plants the seed of protest in the minds of Junior and Wendell, who both express an interest in participating (Act 1, Scene 7). Two of the key organisers of the boycott, Roy Hackett and Paul Stephenson, are mentioned by name (by Wendell in Act 2, Scene 2). The radio announcement in Act 2, Scene 5 quotes Paul Stephenson. Chinonyerem Odimba spoke at length with Paul Stephenson about his role in the Bristol Bus Boycott before writing the play

Princess & The Hustler: literary context

Social realism

Princess & The Hustler doesn't fit neatly into one single literary form. On the surface, it operates as a family drama, but blends real and imagined elements. It is perhaps best thought of as a piece of **social realism**.

It adheres to the following conventions of **social realist** theatre:

Convention	Princess & The Hustler

Depicts the speech patterns of people in real life	• Wendell, speaks in **Jamaican patois**:
	  ○ This often serves to emphasise his difference, and the ways in which he has been othered by society
	
	• Margot too uses a Bristolian **accent** and **dialect**:
	  ○ This positions Margot as a product of the time and place she is in and allows the audience to rationalise her

Focuses on the way real political and social issues affect characters	• Anti-black discrimination and threat of mistreatment or even physical harm of the black community, are mentioned several times throughout the play • Margot in particular embodies tensions between black and white residents in Bristol: ○ This mirrors the tensions between Jamaican migrants and those in England who were resistant to those demographic changes
Uses real historical events as the backdrop for its narrative	• The Bristol Bus Boycott is mentioned a number of times in the play and forms a backdrop for much of its important action
Uses real settings	• The vast majority of the play's action takes place in Princess' family home • Aside from Princess' imagined "cupboard world", the only other setting used in the play is the Bristol Docks (Act 1, Scene 6)

Source

Odimba, Chinonyerem. (2019) *Princess & The Hustler*. Nick Hern Books

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